ENCINO - Holiday toys collected at Little League park - Lawmaker, nonprofits and volunteers amass gifts for upcoming giveaways

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Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel hosted a holiday toy drive Sunday at the Encino Little League Park that drew a crowd who brought toys, games, dollhouses and miniature food play for children in San Fernando Valley. The event wasn't a giveaway; instead it focused on collecting items that will be given to children closer to the holidays.

"It may have been cloudy, but it was all smiles and sunshine at our toy drive where we collected hundreds of toys for kids and families in need," said Gabriel, D-Encino. "At a time when a lot of folks are struggling, it was inspiring to see so many neighbors join together to help make the holidays a bit brighter for kids and families in the San Fernando Valley."

Community members and organizations dropped off hundreds of toys, including from MTO Shahmaghsoudi School of Islamic Sufism in Reseda,

and the Kindness Club at the private Armenian American AGBU Manoogian-Demirdjian School in Canoga Park — a student club that promotes kindness and empathy.

The toys will be distributed in early December by the West Valley Food Pantry and New Economics for Women.

Debbie Decker, executive director and chief operating officer at West Valley Food Pantry, said, "Although the shutdown has ended, insecurity is rife with our community members in need. ... Last year, we gave toys to approximately 650 children. Our fear is that this need will increase greatly this holiday season. We are incredibly grateful to our state Assembly Member, Jesse Gabriel, for his support in getting toy donations for our families."

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